



Figure 4: The default KDE 4.2 RC

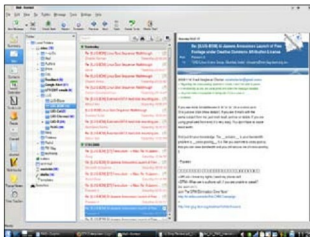


Figure 5: The 'Fancy' theme of KMail

plug-ins for MP3 support and nvidia/ATI graphics drivers the moment you try and install anything using YaST for the first time. So, if you are a free software purist, you better disable the non-free repository first.

Personally, I'd recommend adding the Packman repository before doing anything, and then simply executing `zypper dup` from the command line as the root user. This will pull in all the codec libraries from this third-party repository and you'll have pretty decent multimedia support without trying to search and select the codecs manually. Of course, anything that you find missing afterwards can be searched for later.

By the way, if you use one of those Broadcom wireless chipsets, then you can install the `broadcom-wl-kmp-default` (as well as `broadcom-wl`) package from the Packman repository. These are the Linux drivers that were finally released by Broadcom a while back, so there's no need to depend on `ndiswrapper` or `fwicutter` for wireless support any more (if you so choose).

The final point to mention here is that the KDE 4.1.3 version offered is not the vanilla upstream version. It has a handful of features backported from the KDE 4.2 beta branch also, which is indeed nice for us KDE users. However, I'll say

why settle with 'some' backported features only, when kde.org hosts a KDE 4.2 RC Live CD (which I was talking about earlier; and by the time you read this, the final version would be out) on an openSUSE 11.1 base?

4.2: Come to my window

...crawl inside, wait by the light of the moon. Come to my window, I'll be home soon.

Say, what now? Nothing really... I was just trying to impersonate Melissa Etheridge to make KDE 4.2 come to me faster. Seems like it doesn't work this way.

Anyway, on January 14, I headed to home.kde.org/~binner/kde-four-live to grab the Live CD. (Note that I could have configured the 'KDE4-UNSTABLE-desktop' repository on a base openSUSE 11.1 install to pull in the KDE 4.2 RC packages, but what fun is that?) The added advantage of using this CD is that you can also take a look at the progress of KOffice 2.0 and K3b 2.0 with the included beta releases.

To install the Live CD you can follow the same steps as you would when you install the DVD. Now, after installation, I obviously needed OpenOffice.org, in addition to the English UK translations and support, as well as the GNOME desktop. Of course, I could have pulled everything from the online repository. But why waste time when I already had the DVD handy?

Adding the DVD as an install source is simple: YaST→*Software Repositories*; in the 'Configured Software Repositories' window click *Add*, select the *DVD* radio button, and follow the steps. That's it! Now, open the YaST package manager and install the rest of the software you need. Simple, isn't it? Of course, by the time you read this article, the final KDE 4.2 will be out, so you should check that out.

Now, I know you expect me to talk about what's new in KDE 4.2, but I won't do that. All I can say is it's a brilliant update with really nice features and a sexier interface. What can I say, other than that I'm loving it!

Bottomline

So, where do we really stand? I'll say, whether you want to try KDE 4.2 or not, it doesn't really matter. What matters is that if you are an openSUSE user, this is a 'must' upgrade. And if you aren't an openSUSE user, well, it's certainly worth a try—at least for the sake of being able to quickly get started with KDE 4.2 without waiting for your distro to release its next version after a few months with the updated desktop.

By the way, the news is that the next version of openSUSE will give v4.2 a skip, and straight away bring forth v4.3, which probably will make it the first distro to offer the new desktop version out-of-the-box this summer. Nice to see at least one major distro trying to follow the KDE release schedule instead of GNOME's, for a change. **END** 🐧

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